



Time for Action

Sanghani, shaken by the level of poverty in India, wanted to create better opportunities. And he did not want to wait till he turned 60.

“BY LEAVING THE LAND OF OPPORTUNITIES WE WANTED

to make a statement so that others are motivated enough to join the not-for-profit sector.”

DEVAL SANGHANI, 33 NEERA NUNDY, 34
SOCIAL WORKERS

Sitting at a traffic signal in the plush environs of our car, almost all of us have wondered why we, as a nation, cannot get poor children off the streets. Wall Street analysts Deval Sanghani and wife Neera Nundy didn't just feel it; they did it too by leaving their million-dollar careers in the US to return to India. “Poverty is an accepted thing in India, but because I didn't live in India, I could never accept it,” says Sanghani. As a business analyst for Morgan Stanley on Wall Street, the University of Texas graduate worked closely on private equity deals, where he came across the concept of philanthropic funds. It's also during this time that he met Neera Nundy, a dual graduate in business and statistics, with whom he shared his dream of doing something more meaningful.

After two years on Wall Street, Sanghani returned to

India in 1999 to start Dasra, an institution that provides funding and support to not-for-profit organisations in India. Sanghani, now based in Mumbai, believes India lacks processes that make NGOs sustainable and scalable. Instead of starting a new institution, Sanghani decided to bring management skills to a sector which is not known to attract talent. By 2004, Sanghani was joined by Nundy after she had completed her business degree from Harvard University.

In the last 10 years, Dasra has worked with 75 NGOs and directed \$5 million towards their projects. While funding projects is easy, creating sustainable institutions around them is not and that's what Sanghani seeks to achieve. Dasra raises funds in the US from rich NRIs and invests them in high-potential institutions engaged in philanthropic projects in India. As a rule Dasra does not run any not-for-profit institution, but the couple have chosen to make an exception for Sharanam, a shelter for girls in Dharavi, which they run along with the Community Outreach Programme.

Ask the duo whether they miss their million-dollar bonuses and Nundy's reply is: “The sight of street children going to school drives us.” Going forward, Dasra seeks to raise funds locally and invest them in five institutions in a more focused way.

by Malini Bhupta